

Replicating Mondak & Sanders (2003): Tolerance and Intolerance, 1976–1998

DWV Assignment 6

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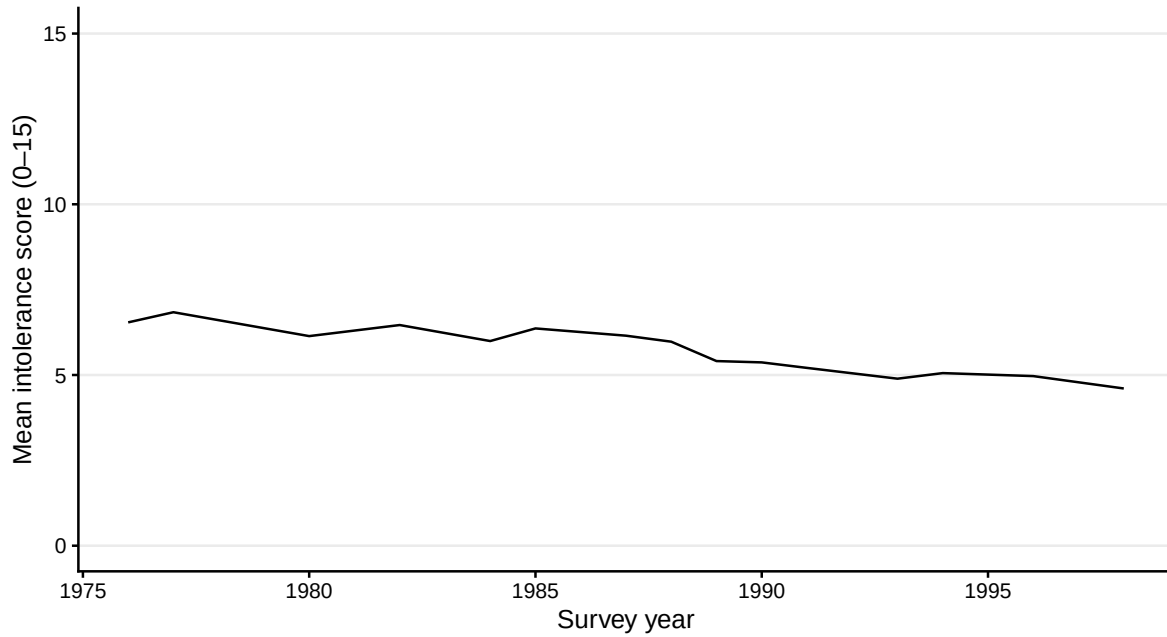
All code used to clean the data and build the figures is in `ps6.R` in the accompanying GitHub repository: https://github.com/josharden-jpa/DWV_PS6.

Replication

Figure 1: The 0–15 Tolerance Battery

The 0–15 GSS Modified Stouffer Tolerance Battery, 1976–1998

High scores represent intolerance



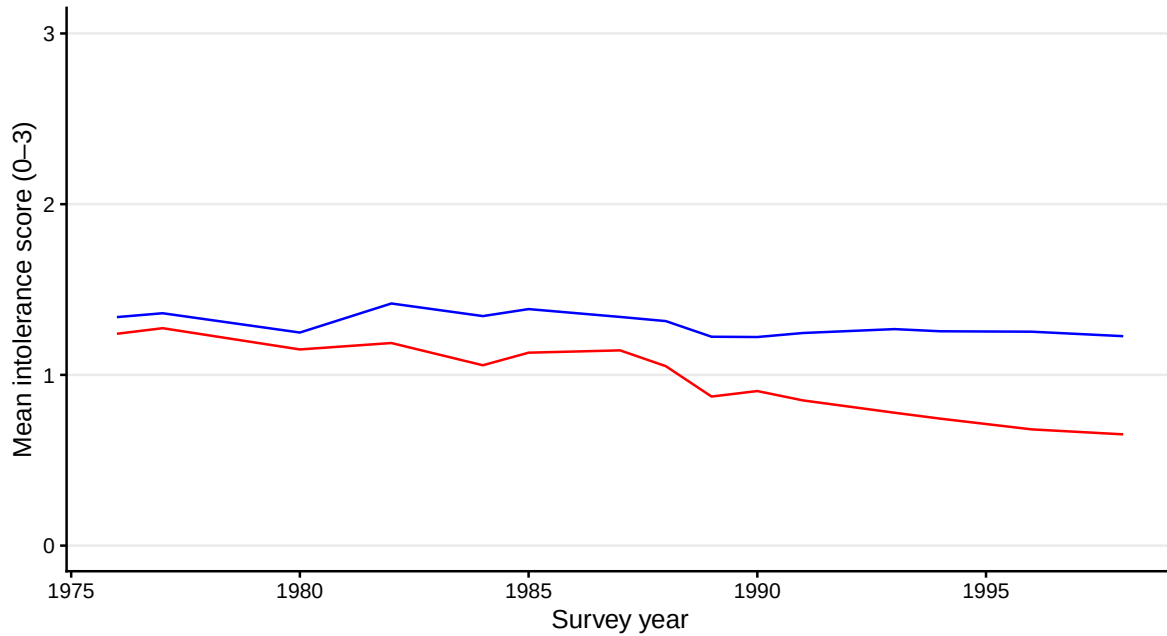
Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

Figure 1: Mean score on the 15-item GSS modified Stouffer battery, 1976–1998. Higher scores represent greater intolerance.

Figure 2: Intolerance Toward Racists and Homosexuals

Intolerance Toward Racists and Homosexuals, 1976–1998

Blue = racists; red = homosexuals



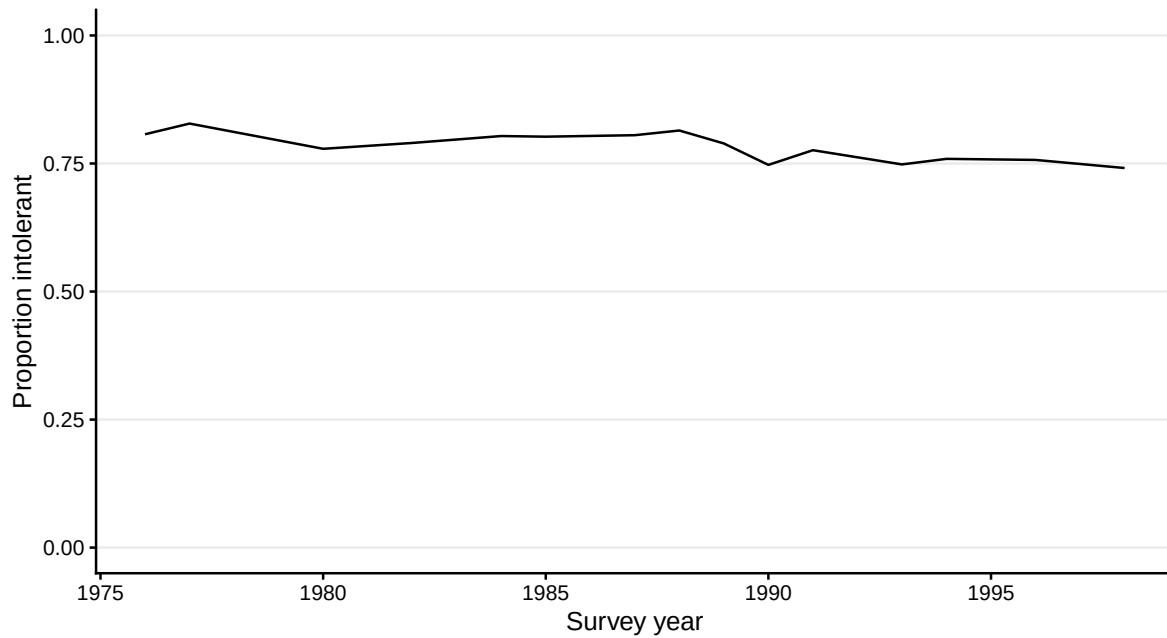
Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

Figure 2: Mean score on the three tolerance items for each target group, 1976–1998 (0 = fully tolerant, 3 = fully intolerant).

Figure 5: A Dichotomous Measure of Intolerance

A Dichotomous Measure of Tolerance and Intolerance, 1976–1998

Intolerant = any score above 0 out of 15



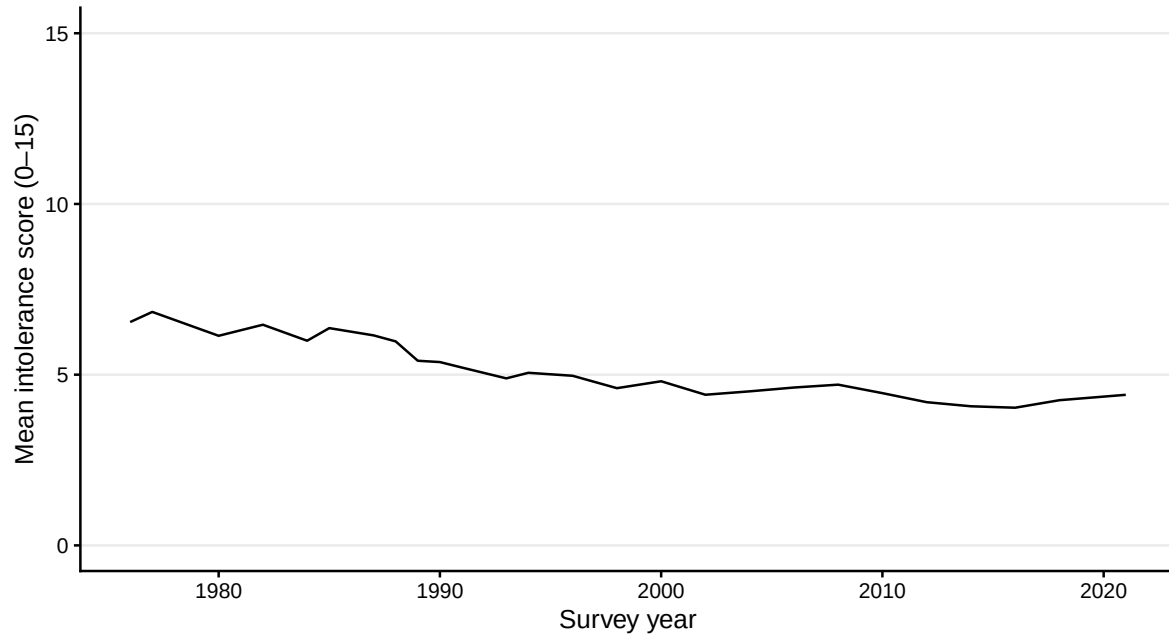
Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

Figure 3: Share of respondents giving at least one intolerant answer on the 15-item battery, 1976–1998.

Extension: All Available Years

The 0–15 Tolerance Battery, All Years

High scores represent intolerance

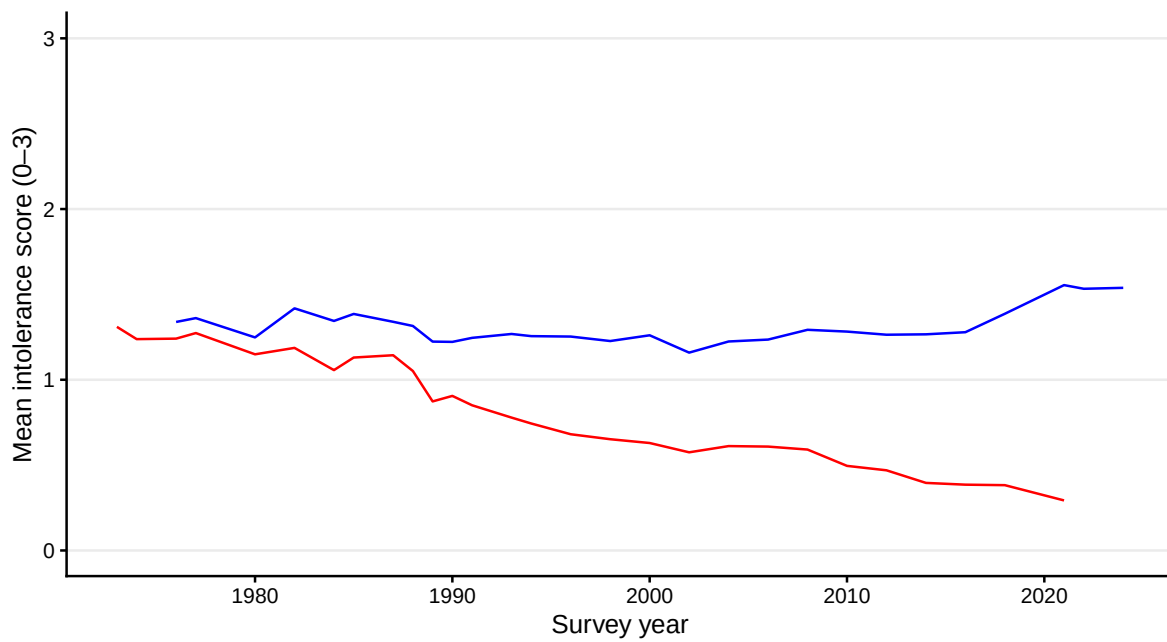


Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

Figure 4: Figure 1 extended through 2024.

Intolerance Toward Racists and Homosexuals, All Years

Blue = racists; red = homosexuals

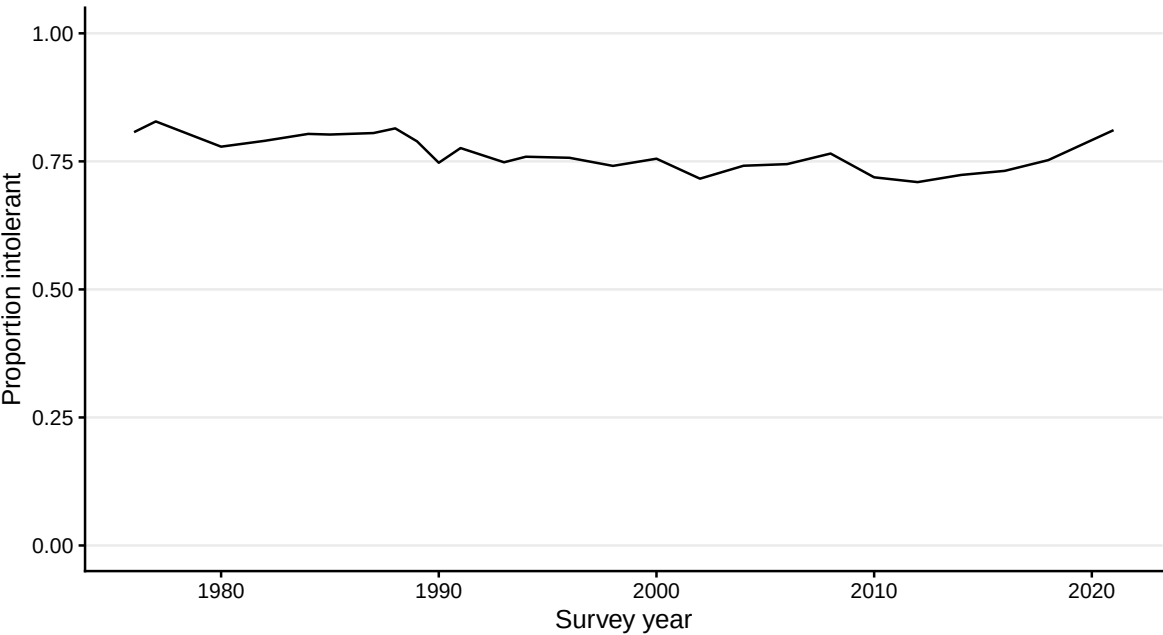


Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

Figure 5: Figure 2 extended through 2024.

Dichotomous Measure of Intolerance, All Years

Intolerant = any score above 0 out of 15



Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

Figure 6: Figure 5 extended through 2024.

Original Work: Two GSS Variables in 2024

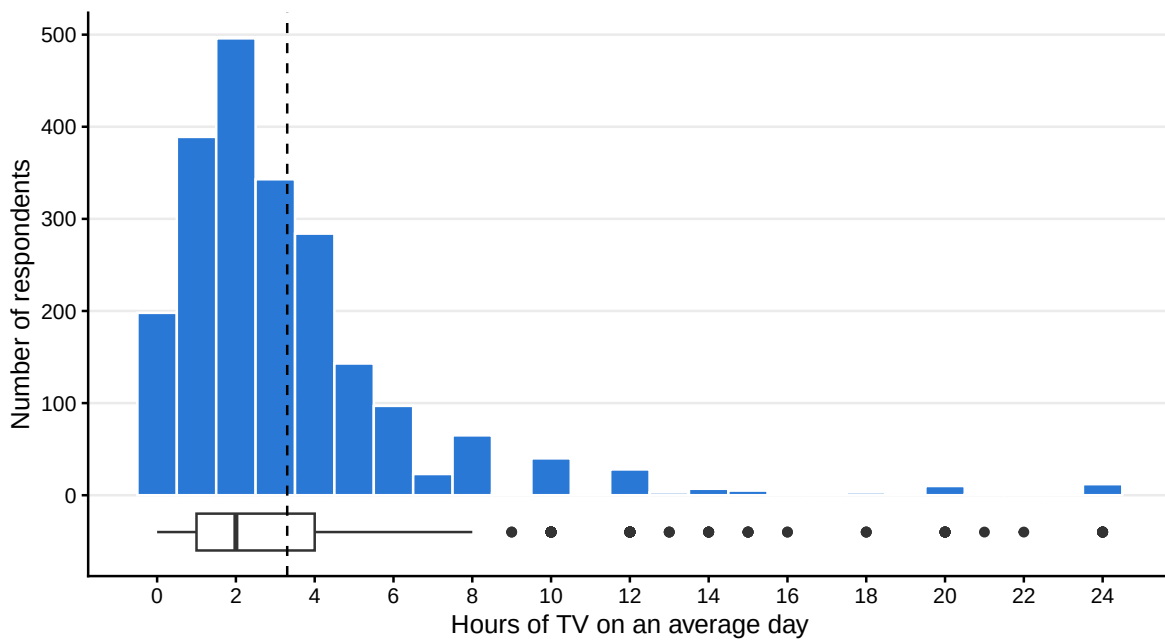
Television Viewing (TVHOURS)

Table 1: Summary statistics for daily hours of television, 2024 GSS.

N	Mean	Median	SD	25th pct.	75th pct.	Max
2152	3.3	2	3.3	1	4	24

Daily Television Viewing, 2024

Bars show the number of respondents; box shows median and middle 50%; dashed line = mean



Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

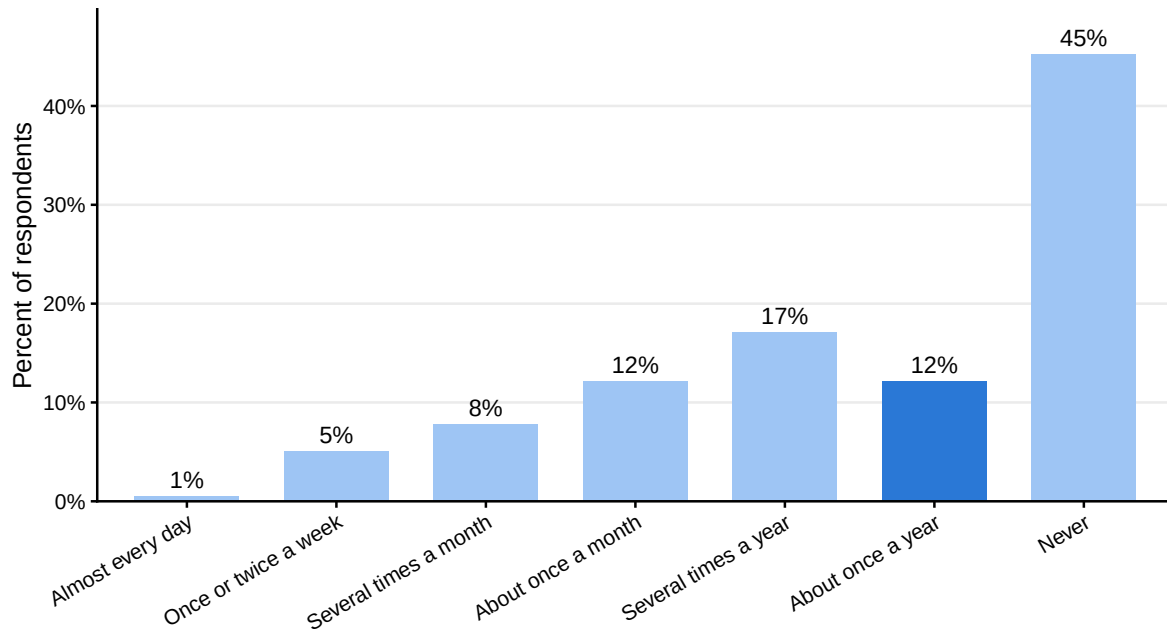
Figure 7: Distribution of self-reported daily television viewing, 2024 GSS.

The most common answer is two hours, given by about 500 respondents, and the median is also two hours. The mean, however, is a little over three hours. The middle 50% of respondents watch between one and four hours a day. The mean is pulled upward by outliers who report watching 20 or 24 hours a day, which probably means they literally never turn their TV off, even while they are sleeping. The distribution is skewed right: most answers bunch up around one, two, and three hours, with a small tail stretching out to the right.

Going to a Bar or Tavern (SOCBAR)

How Often Americans Go to a Bar or Tavern, 2024

Dark bar = median answer (About once a year); middle 50% range from 'About once a month' to 'Never'



Source: General Social Survey (GSS) cumulative file, 1972–2024.

Figure 8: How often respondents go to a bar or tavern, 2024 GSS.

The median answer is “about once a year,” which is quite surprising to me, and 45% of respondents never go to a bar or tavern at all. I can understand never going, but I would like to know what the occasion is for the people who go once a year. Maybe it is for their own birthday, or for New Year’s, the one night out with friends. Apart from a small bump from “about once a year” to “several times a year,” the number of respondents decreases as the frequency increases. In other words, the more trips to the bar an answer represents, the fewer respondents give that answer. The middle 50% of respondents fall between “about once a month” and “never.” Technically, that range covers four of the seven answer categories, but in substance the answers are not far apart: everyone in the middle half goes to a bar once a month at most.

Discussion

1. Problems With the Replication

The main problems I encountered in this replication were figuring out how the responses were coded and how to properly recode them, and working out whether each score should run from 0 to 15 or from 0 to 3. It was also tricky to determine exactly what kind of graph was being used in the original figures.

There was also a bug in my first version of Figure 2. When calculating the scores for intolerance toward homosexuals, I used the wrong data object (the one that had not been filtered to 1976–1998 or recoded). Because none of the recoded columns existed in that object, every respondent got a score of 0, and the line for homosexuals showed up flat at zero across all years. Once I used the correctly filtered and recoded data, the line matched the paper’s downward trend.

2. Interpreting Figures 1, 2, and 5

In Figure 1, the mean intolerance score drops by roughly 27% between 1977 and 1998. This doesn’t tell us about any one particular group: some answers could be becoming more tolerant while others become less tolerant. Overall, though, people are scoring as more tolerant than they were decades ago.

Figure 2 shows that while intolerance toward racists stays relatively the same, intolerance toward homosexuals declines. So even though people don’t feel any better or worse about racists, they do become more tolerant toward homosexuals over the same period. In other words, it isn’t that people overall are disliking bigotry more; by this scoring, they are presumably becoming more accepting of homosexuality. This changes how Figure 1 should be read: it could be that only tolerance toward the specific groups named in the questions has risen, while overall intolerance, especially toward new ideas and groups beyond the ones the questions were about at the time, has not.

Figure 5 shows that the proportion of people who were intolerant in any way has gone down. About 15% of respondents answered tolerant to all of the questions in 1988, compared with 21% in 1998. Even so, a significant portion of respondents, roughly four in five, remain intolerant of at least one group.

3. What Has Changed Since 1998?

Many things have changed since 1998. Looking at intolerance toward homosexuals, for example, same-sex marriage is now legal nationwide. This could show that attitudes were already trending toward acceptance, or the newer norms, standards, and laws might in turn lead people

to become more tolerant because same-sex relationships are more normalized. There has also been a lot of division since 1998, and many events could have a big effect on how people answer the tolerance questions. These include 9/11, which caused a lot of intolerance toward Muslim and Arab people. So some of the scores might be different for different reasons.